

# **Stable Affordable Housing – Position Paper**

## **SUN PRIORITY:**

To advocate for a provincial program which will address improving senior affordable housing in the Province of Alberta.

## **ISSUE:**

More stable affordable housing is a priority for Alberta seniors. The existing units of government affordable housing are in disrepair. The previous government had announced that 1.2 billion dollars are needed to bring these units up to approved government living standards. Also, the number of government approved housing units continues to be inadequate. The previous government had announced that an amount of 1.2 billion dollars has been approved to expand affordable housing by 3000 units.

## **BACKGROUND:**

Affordable housing is defined as government supported housing for persons who because of financial, social or other circumstances cannot afford private market rental rates. Housing is considered “affordable” if the cost is no more than 30 percent of a person or family’s gross income.

The problem of affordable housing affects numerous marginalized groups including single-parent families, recent immigrants, youth, seniors, disabled and indigenous persons. The 2018 Housing Needs Assessment Report completed by The City of Calgary indicated that the magnitude of affordable housing need annually is 2,000 new units which outstrips by 1,700 the supply increase per year of 300 new units. This report can be accessed at:

[www.calgary.ca/CS/OLSH/Documents/Affordable-Housing-Needs-Assessment.pdf](http://www.calgary.ca/CS/OLSH/Documents/Affordable-Housing-Needs-Assessment.pdf)

Clearly, Edmonton and other major Albertan cities would be similarly impacted.

However, this discussion will focus on seniors specifically and their need for affordable housing.

Female seniors often have lower pensions and limited savings because they generally held lower paying jobs and may have had employment interruptions because of child or parent care responsibilities. For these reasons, their contributions to the Canada Pension Plan (CPP) are lower and subsequent benefits lower. With little or no contributions to CPP, female seniors may have to rely solely on Old Age Security (OAS) and the Guaranteed Income Supplement (GIS) pension benefits. Currently, OAS is \$601.45, and GIS is \$898.32 or \$1,499.77 monthly. In this example, 30 percent of this gross income would reflect a maximum rent of \$450.00 per month.

The Alberta government works with a variety of housing providers, including municipalities, housing management bodies, non-profit and private sector organizations, to build and operate affordable housing for Albertans with low income such as seniors. To be eligible for these affordable housing programs, applicants must have an income below local income limits as determined by the market for the community in which they live.

The Seniors Self-contained Housing Program provides apartment-style housing to seniors who are able to live independently with or without assistance of community-based services.

The Seniors Lodge Program offers rooms, meals, services and recreational opportunities for independent seniors.

Rent supplement programs include the Private landlord rent supplement, and the Direct to tenant rent supplement.

More details of the Alberta government 's affordable housing programs, local income limits and how to apply for housing can be found at:

[www.alberta.ca/affordable-housing-programs.aspx](http://www.alberta.ca/affordable-housing-programs.aspx)

### **SUN MEMBERSHIP RECOMMENDATIONS:**

Due to the current need for Affordable Housing in Alberta, SUN members and the Board of Directors forward the following recommendations:

- 1) The Government of Alberta implement a program and a committed budget to bring the current Affordable Housing units up to Government standards.
- 2) The Government of Alberta implement a program and a committed budget to expand the available Affordable Housing units up in Alberta to meet the current need.

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